



Puppy Foundations

Premium practice worksheet

PUPPY FOUNDATIONS · LESSON 05

Teach curiosity, not pressure.

This worksheet helps owners build healthy exposure to people, places, sounds, and surfaces without overwhelming the puppy.

TRAINER NOTE

Socialization is not about meeting everything. It is about learning that the world is safe enough to observe and recover from.

START HERE

Dog: _____

Date: _____

Owner: _____

Best reward: _____

1 What success looks like

By the end of this lesson, the owner can create short, positive exposure sessions that help the puppy notice new things and stay able to eat, play, and recover.

2 Practice plan

1

Observe first

Start at a distance where your puppy can notice the new thing and stay relaxed.

2

Pair with rewards

Mark calm looks, choosing to investigate, or checking back in with you.

3

Leave early

End while your puppy is still successful, not after they are done coping.

4

Vary the list slowly

Repeat good exposures and add new ones in small doses over time.



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Puppy Socialization the Right Way

3 Supplies and setup

Supplies needed

- ☐ Soft, easy treats
- ☐ Mat or towel for a safe settle spot
- ☐ Leash and harness
- ☐ List of people, places, sounds, and surfaces to explore

Set up before you start

- ☐ Choose low-pressure locations with room to leave.
- ☐ Plan one or two exposure goals per outing, not ten.
- ☐ Make sure the puppy is rested before the session.

4 Socialization session tracker

Date	New thing	Setup	Response	Recovered?	Notes

5 5-day practice micro plan

Day 1

Set baseline

Find the easiest version and keep it calm.

Day 2

Repeat wins

Practice the same setup until it looks smooth.

Day 3

Add one tiny step

Add only one small challenge if yesterday

Day 4

Hold or simplify

If your puppy struggled, make today easier.

Day 5

Review notes

Choose the safest next step from your log.



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6 Common mistakes and quick fixes

Common mistakes

- Letting strangers or dogs rush in to greet the puppy.
- Staying too long because the puppy is "handling it."
- Trying to socialize in very busy environments first.
- Ignoring signs of fatigue, freezing, or avoidance.

If this happens, try this

- If the puppy stops taking treats, increase distance or leave.
- If the puppy gets wiggly and nippy after an outing, the session may have been too much.
- If a greeting matters, keep it brief and end before the puppy checks out.

7 Ready to progress?

- ☐ I can identify when my puppy is curious vs. overwhelmed.
- ☐ I am using distance to keep sessions easy.
- ☐ My puppy can take treats and recover during new experiences.
- ☐ I end outings before my puppy becomes depleted.

HOMEWORK

Plan three socialization outings this week. Include one new sound, one new surface, and one calm observation from a distance.

8 Owner reflection

Biggest win: _____

What made it easier: _____

What should I repeat tomorrow: _____

QUESTIONS FOR YOUR FITDOG TRAINER

What should I make easier? _____

What should I practice again? _____

What is the next realistic step? _____